

Mastodons An extinct group of large mammals with trunks, tusks, and thick hair. They were related to the elephants.

Meganeura A kind of giant dragonfly (more correctly called a griffinfly) that lived in the Carboniferous Period. *Meganeura* was possibly the largest insect ever found on Earth.

Metamorphosis A major change in an organism when it takes on its adult form. The change from caterpillar to butterfly is an example of metamorphosis.

Migration A long-distance journey undertaken by animals moving to new homes. Many birds migrate in autumn in order to spend winter in warmer countries.

Molluscs A large group of invertebrate species that includes slugs, snails, clams, octopuses, and squids. Many molluscs produce hard shells that fossilize easily, making mollusc fossils common.

Mosasaurus Giant, sea-dwelling lizards that lived during the Cretaceous Period. They were fierce predators with slender bodies, long snouts, and flipper-like limbs.

Natural selection The natural “weeding out” of animals and plants that drives evolution.

Neanderthal (*Homo neanderthalensis*) An extinct species of hominin that is very closely related to our own species. Neanderthals lived in Europe and Asia during the last ice age.

Neogene The period of history from 23 million years ago to today. The Neogene Period is divided into the Miocene, Pliocene, Pleistocene, and Holocene epochs.

Nocturnal Awake and active during the night. Nocturnal animals include owls, bats, and cats.

Nothosaurs A group of large, sea-dwelling reptiles that lived in the Triassic Period. Nothosaurs resembled seals and came ashore to breed.

Omnivore An animal that eats both plant and animal food. Examples include pigs, rats, and human beings.

Ordovician The second period in the Palaeozoic Era, from 488 to 444 million years ago. All animals known from this time lived in water.

Ornithischians (bird-hipped dinosaurs) One of two major divisions into which the dinosaur family tree is split (see also Saurischians). Ornithischians were plant eaters with beaked mouths.

Ornithomimids (ostrich dinosaurs) Tall, slender, bird-like dinosaurs that were built like ostriches. They were the fastest animals on land in the Cretaceous Period.

Paleogene The first period in the Cenozoic Era, from 65 to 23 million years ago. The Paleogene is divided into the Paleocene, Eocene, and Oligocene epochs.

Palaeontology The scientific study of fossil plants and animals.

Pampas Treeless, grass-covered plains in South America.

Pangaea A supercontinent that formed at the end of the Palaeozoic Era. Pangaea contained nearly all of Earth's land and stretched from the North Pole to the South Pole.

Pelvis The part of an animal's skeleton that forms the hips.

Pelycosaurs A group of large, reptile-like animals that lived before the age of the dinosaurs. Scientists believe that mammals evolved from these creatures.

Period A very long unit of time, lasting millions of years. The Jurassic is a period.

Permafrost Permanently frozen ground found in places such as northern Canada and Siberia. Although the surface thaws out and becomes boggy in summer, the deeper soil remains frozen solid.



Permian The last period of the Palaeozoic Era, from 299 to 251 million years ago. The end of the Permian saw a worldwide mass extinction in which most animal species were wiped out.

Placentals Mammals whose unborn young are nourished by a special organ called a placenta. Placental mammals have replaced marsupials in most parts of the world.

Placoderm (armoured fish) A class of prehistoric fish that had body armour formed from plates of bone. They flourished in the Devonian Period.

Plesiosaurs Large, prehistoric marine reptiles that swam with flipper-shaped limbs. Many had enormously long necks and tiny heads. Others (called pliosaurs) had short necks and huge heads with powerful, fang-lined jaws.

Precambrian The great span of time lasting from Earth's formation 4.6 billion years ago to the start of the Cambrian Period 542 million years ago. For most of the Precambrian, the only forms of life were microscopic, single-celled organisms that lived in water.

Predator An animal that hunts, kills, and eats other animals.

Preservation Keeping something, for example a fossil, free from harm or decay.

Prey An animal that is hunted, killed, and eaten by a predator.

Primates The group of mammals that includes lemurs, monkeys, apes, and humans.

Primitive At an early stage of evolution.

